



YOU ARE **37 WEEKS AND 1 DAY**

20 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

Full term has been reached and your baby's features are now very clearly formed. From now on, your baby is simply growing and gaining weight—factors that are necessary to provide energy after birth and help with temperature control.

“Start preparing for the birth now: by being practical and positive, you can make it memorable for all the right reasons.”

Probably the most effective way to remember as much as you can about your labor and the birth of your baby is to try to remain as healthy and rested as possible prior to the start of your labor; this will give you the best chance of staying strong and clear-headed throughout.

Feeling strong and having plenty of energy may also help you remain upright and active during the course of your labor, reducing the need for pain relief such as Demerol (see [Opioids](#)), which can sometimes cause memory loss that makes it more difficult to remember the finer details of the birth. It's also helpful to have your birth partner with you throughout your labor so that they can help fill in any blanks later. Photographs and videos are also good prompts.

If you find that there are parts of labor and delivery that you can't remember, you can ask your doctor to review this with you. You might want to consider writing about your experience in a journal.

HYPNOSIS

Being hypnotized during pregnancy can make you more confident in the lead-up to labor. A study found that first-time pregnant women also experienced a shorter labor. The average amount of time they pushed in the second stage was one hour, compared with the usual two hours for a first baby.

FOCUS ON PARTNERS

When you get closer to the birth, and especially during labor, you will find that there is inevitably more contact with health professionals. These individuals are a source of reassurance and a font of knowledge, but as a partner, you may sometimes feel that you're being sidelined or that your opinion doesn't count.

This can be very frustrating if you want to be highly involved in the pregnancy and birth.